

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Interfaces

It's coming, the time when everything will just connect to everything else. For now, we have all these terms for the things our components need to communicate. Get the basics here, then go brag.

ISA: The Industry Standard Architecture was introduced for IBM computers in the computer stone-age years of 1981-83. Users had to know the ins and outs of the hardware they were going to install. Stuff like the IRQ line and the I/O address had to be entered manually—you can imagine why this was phased out quickly!

SCSI: Small Computer System Interface (pronounced *suzziy*) is the standard interface used to connect storage devices in commercial computers and for transferring large volumes of data on high-performance RAID servers.

ATA: Those broad, flat wires inside your computer cabinet... Advanced Technology Attachment is designed to connect storage devices like hard drives and CD-ROM drives. The cables can only be up to 36 inches long.

PCI: Peripheral Component Interconnect refers to a computer bus for attaching peripherals to a motherboard; for example, RAM. This interface allows for all hardware to be identified during bootup process, disabling hardware that may conflict.

Fibre Channel: Ever wondered how supercomputers transfer such large volumes of data so quickly? Fibre Channel is a gigabit transfer interface, running on fibre-optic wires, transferring very large volumes of data, very quickly. Don't we wish we had a few of these in the office...

Usage: Thank God for *SCSI* and *PCI*—I remember the *ISA* days—they sucked! Can't wait for everything to go *Fibre Channel*?

Wild Wild Web

The Wild, Wide Reach Of The Net

Inspired by a YouTube video that showed a man hugging strangers, pretty much *Munna Bhai*-style, Ryan Fitzgerald put up his own video on YouTube. "I never met you, but I do care," he went, offering to speak to anyone who cared to call—to lend a listening ear, as it were. He says he sincerely wanted to be a good listener.

He received over 5,000 calls.

The calls Fitzgerald received even came from faraway places like Sweden and London, but there were also some frightening calls, including one from a man who threatened Fitzgerald

with violence if he didn't meet him.

A Northeastern University criminologist, Jack Levin, says he feels Fitzgerald has taken a "terrible risk" by putting himself up on the Internet.

The video will probably be taken off YouTube upon the request of Fitzgerald himself, our *Sixth Sense* tells us. So if that's happened by the time you read this, doff your hats to us!

Botgangs!

Did you know there were gangs on the Internet? That you might be the owner of a zombie computer? That the gangs are vying for control over it? How awful!

For the evil ones who have entered the murky waters of spam and botnet-creation (a botnet is a network of zombie computers, which unwittingly relay spam), it's all about territory and control—just like with real-life gangs. AV researchers at Kaspersky Labs have identified three criminal gangs: those behind the Bagle, WarezoV, and Zhelatin worms. Even as you read this, they are trying to rid zombie computers of rival-gang malware to be able to install their own!

You're part of all this if you don't use anti-stuff! You own either a Bagle or a WarezoV or a Zhelatin computer! Believe it...

one's sure how many. OK, so what do they Google up? "trigger happy," "iraq war," "world trade center." You're thinking we're making this up, of course. Suit yourselves—check out the Zeitgeist! Yes, Afghans seem to have caught on that the world calls them "trigger-happy," and they probably want to check what exactly the phrase means. And they're still stuck on 9/11.

Actually, ranked even higher than the above is "sunny deol photo." Just might have something to do with the movie in which Deol's wife ends up in Pakistan, but we're speculating. They're also interested in "jennifer loopez."

In neighbouring Iraq, where, too, we didn't know the Internet was popular, at #8 is "iraq." Do they do that in the spiritual sense of "finding oneself"? Or are they wondering whether their map has changed since they last saw it? Corny guesses, and this one beats us. What doesn't stump us, however, is "ako" (Army Knowledge Online) at #1, and "sexy" at #14. How cute.

If Afghans are looking for Sunny Deol, Singaporeans are looking



for "hrithink roshan." No typo there. Sheer wonderment: it's Deol in one country, and Roshan in another. Seems all random to us.

No good Indian magazine can leave out talk of Pakistan, and there are some nice ones there. Bollywood again: "salman" at #5.

Apparently, a lot of women in Pakistan use the Internet: "beauty tips" stands at #1. But even if women there are progressive, it does look like people are still getting online for the first time and all that: "internet" is at #10, and they're behind the times—"anna kournikova" is still in their top 15. (The rest of the world got over that skirt a long while ago, as you'll recollect.) And, oh,

"uk" is at #15: they all want to get there eventually, as you know all too well.

Now, if we're talking about Pakistan, we've got to talk about ourselves as well, to be fair. We're a bit better off, searching for "real estate india" (#2)—what with prices doing the roller-coaster. But at #1 is—surprise—"jolie". People still hung up on her? And not "Angelina Jolie," but just "jolie"? What gives...?

The Norwegians search for "fat people" at 10,000 Gbps. We figure they're looking to make fun of Americans, because the popular conception in Europe of the typical American heavily involves obesity. "Fairies" play a role in the Norwegian scheme of things: it's at #11, so they probably believe in them. Fitting: since they have 1,00,000 Tbps, they're in fairyland anyway.

And finally, here's about how a single phone model can take a nation by storm: in Turkey, they search a hell of a lot for "samsung e 250." Not just Samsung, not just "samsung cell phone": specifically the Samsung E250. If you have one of these, do write in and tell us what's ultra-special about it! We'd love to know!